HKU BUSINESS SCHOOL
港大經管學院

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The University of Hong Kong
Faculty of Business and Economics

MACC 7013 International Tax and Transfer Pricing
Course Outline 2026-2027

Course Instructor

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Class Day & Time:
Class Dates:
Consultation: By appointment.
Teaching Assistant: TBA

Course Description

As multinational enterprises (MNEs) expand across jurisdictions, they face complex tax rules, greater scrutiny, and rapidly evolving international standards. This course provides an overview of international tax and transfer pricing for managers.

We begin with core concepts in tax planning and international taxation, including how domestic rules interact with double tax treaties, withholding taxes, foreign tax credits, and exemption regimes. Building on this foundation, we then focus on transfer pricing, covering the delineation of intra-group transactions, functional and risk analysis, method selection, and pricing adjustments. We next apply these concepts to structures involving intangibles and intra-group financing, and consider how controversy prevention and resolution mechanisms operate in practice. These topics are illustrated using examples from different industries and real-world cases. From there, we widen the lens to discuss anti-avoidance measures such as the OECD/G20 BEPS project, including recent developments (e.g., the Pillar Two global minimum tax rules), and related tax transparency requirements, such as Country-by-Country Reporting (CbCR) and GRI 207, the sustainability reporting standard on tax transparency. Finally, we discuss the taxation of basic deal structures in mergers and acquisitions.

By the end of the course, students will be able to analyze common cross-border structures, identify major international tax risks for MNEs, and assess how tax and transfer pricing rules influence business decisions.

The course is highly relevant for business managers, strategy consultants, investment bankers, and financial analysts. The course is open to all students, and prior tax knowledge is not required.

Textbook and Course Materials

Course Materials: The lecture slides, case materials, and supplementary readings for the course will be accessible for download on HKU Moodle.

Course Objectives

1. Develop a rigorous understanding of the interactions between domestic and international tax rules, including double tax treaties, withholding taxes, foreign tax credits, and exemption regimes.
2. Build practical competence in transfer pricing from a tax perspective, including the delineation of intra-group transactions, functional and risk analysis, method selection, pricing adjustments, and the design of structures involving intangibles and intra-group financing.
3. Enable students to identify and manage key tax risks faced by multinational enterprises, including controversy prevention and resolution mechanisms and the tax implications of basic mergers and acquisitions deal structures.

4. Provide an integrated view of the evolving global tax environment, with a focus on anti-avoidance and transparency regimes (such as the OECD/G20 BEPS project, Pillar Two, Country-by-Country Reporting, and sustainability reporting standards like GRI 207 on tax transparency), and their implications for multinational tax planning.

Course Learning Outcomes (CLOs)

CLO1. Understand and explain core concepts in international tax planning and corporate income taxation for MNEs, including the interaction of domestic rules with double tax treaties, withholding taxes, foreign tax credits, and exemption regimes.

CLO2. Analyze and apply transfer pricing principles to intra-group transactions, including delineation of controlled transactions, functional and risk analysis, method selection, pricing adjustments, and their application to intangibles and intra-group financing.

CLO3. Identify and evaluate international tax and transfer pricing risks in common cross-border structures and basic mergers and acquisitions (M&A) deals, and understand the role of controversy prevention and resolution mechanisms in managing these risks.

CLO4. Assess the implications of anti-avoidance and transparency regimes (such as the OECD/G20 BEPS project, Pillar Two, Country-by-Country Reporting, and tax-related sustainability reporting standards like GRI 207) for multinational tax planning, and effectively communicate their business impact to non-specialist stakeholders.

Alignments of Learning Outcomes

Program Learning Outcomes	Course Learning Outcomes
1. Acquiring and internalizing accounting and business knowledge and skills	CLO1, CLO2, CLO3
2. Applying and integrating of business knowledge	CLO2, CLO3
3. Inculcating professionalism and leadership	CLO4
4. Developing global outlook	CLO2, CLO3
5. Mastering communication skills	CLO3, CLO4

Teaching and Learning Activities (TLAs)

TLA1: Interactive lectures

The concepts are explained and illustrated by the instructor through interactive lectures using PowerPoint slides, while students are invited to share their views and experiences in applying the concepts.

TLA2: In-class discussions

Discussion questions are raised by the instructor during class, with students being prompted to actively participate by sharing their opinions with their peers.

TLA3: Homework assignments

As part of the course requirements, students will need to submit homework assignments. These assignments provide a practical learning opportunity for students to apply the analytical skills taught throughout the course.

TLA4: Group project

For case analysis, students are required to form groups, prepare their work, and deliver a brief presentation.

Course Assessment Components

	Assessment Methods	Weights	Course Learning Outcomes
1.	Attendance and participation (regular lectures)	15%	CLO1, CLO2, CLO3
2.	Attendance and participation (guest lectures, e.g., tax partner(s) from a Big N firm)	10%	CLO1, CLO2, CLO3
3.	Individual homework assignments	20%	CLO1, CLO2, CLO3, CLO4
4.	Group project	20%	CLO1, CLO2, CLO3
5.	In-class quizzes (two)	35%	CLO4
	Total	100%	

Class Attendance: An attendance rate of 70% is required for all Master of Accounting courses. Failure to meet the 70% attendance requirement will result in a fail grade in the course concerned.

Grading Criteria for Assessments 1 and 2: Students are strongly encouraged to prepare for class discussions, participate actively, and submit all homework assignments on time.

A+, A, A-	B+, B, B-	C+, C, C-	D+, D	F
Highly engaged in discussions, consistently contributed valuable insights, and attended ≥90% of classes. Completed all homework with a score ≥90%.	Moderately prepared for discussion, somewhat active in sharing views, and attended ≥80% of classes. Completed ≥80% of homework with a score ≥80%.	Not well prepared for discussion, did not actively participate in discussions, and attended ≥70% of classes. Completed ≥70% of homework with a score ≥70%.	Unprepared for discussion, did not contribute to discussions, and attended ≥60% of classes. Completed ≥60% of homework with a score ≥60%.	Poorly for discussion, did not contribute to discussions, and attended <60% of classes. Completed <60% of homework with a score <60%.

Grading Criteria for Assessment 3: Students will form their own groups to work on a group project, which involves a written report and a group presentation.

A+, A, A-	B+, B, B-	C+, C, C-	D+, D	F
The project demonstrates an outstanding level of understanding of the topic. The topic was presented in an exceptionally professional and meticulously organized manner.	The project demonstrates a strong level of understanding of most aspects of the topic. The topic was presented in a highly professional and well-structured manner.	The project exhibits a good level of understanding of most aspects of the topic. The topic was presented in a well-organized manner.	The project shows a basic level of understanding of most of the topic. The topic was covered in a general manner without exploring specific details.	The project demonstrates a lack of satisfactory understanding of the topic. The topic was inadequately covered and the presentation was poorly organized.

Grading Criteria for Assessment 4: In-class quizzes covering topics in the course syllabus will be administered in class to reinforce the key knowledge taught.

A+, A, A-	B+, B, B-	C+, C, C-	D+, D	F
The student demonstrated high proficiency by accurately solving all problems, giving detailed and insightful responses to essay questions.	The student demonstrated proficiency by accurately solving some problems, providing detailed responses to some essay questions.	The student demonstrated partial proficiency by accurately solving a few problems, providing limited responses to essay questions.	The student demonstrated limited proficiency by accurately solving only a very few problems, providing unclear responses to essay questions.	The student demonstrated very limited proficiency by skipping problems and/or providing inaccurate solutions to most problems, giving poor responses to essay questions.

Academic Dishonesty

The University takes academic dishonesty very seriously and will strictly enforce its regulations on the matter. You can find more information about plagiarism in the University Statement on Plagiarism at https://tl.hku.hk/plagiarism.

Academic dishonesty is behavior in which a deliberately fraudulent misrepresentation is employed in an attempt to gain undeserved intellectual credit, either for oneself or for another. It includes, but is not necessarily limited to, the following types of cases:

1. Plagiarism: The representation of someone else's ideas as if they are one's own. Where the arguments, data, designs, etc., of someone else are being used in a paper, report, oral presentation, or similar academic project, this fact must be made explicitly clear by citing the appropriate references. The references must fully indicate the extent to which any parts of the project are not one's own work. **Paraphrasing of someone else's ideas is still using someone else's ideas, and must be acknowledged.**
2. Cheating in assessments (e.g., quizzes, tests, or exams): The covert gathering of information from other students, the use of unauthorized notes, unauthorized aids, etc.

Topics

1	Fundamental concepts in tax planning
2	Introduction to international taxation
3	Transfer pricing: fundamentals, intangibles, and cases
4	Anti-avoidance measures: OECD Pillar 1, Pillar 2
5	Tax transparency measures
6	Tax structuring: M&A
7	Others: e.g., Carbon tax, China tax issues
8	Guest lectures conducted by Tax Partner(s) & Info session on tax career and recruiting
9	Group project presentations